

Crotalus atrox

Western diamondback rattlesnake



Location S. USA, N. Mexico

Length	Up to 6½ ft (2 m)
Breeding	Viviparous
Habit	Terrestrial
Status	Least concern



This large, heavy-bodied snake is North America's most dangerous rattlesnake, with the highest rate of human fatalities. A highly venomous and effective hunter, the western diamondback rattlesnake feeds mainly on small mammals, birds, and lizards, but can be deadly to larger animals or humans, if provoked. The rattle, its most distinctive feature, is a horny section at the end of the tail

composed of loosely connected segments, which are added to after each shedding. Used to warn and deter intruders, the rattle consists of up to 16 segments in adults. Newborns, measuring about 12 in (30 cm), do not possess a rattle, but instead have a small "button" that develops with sloughing. However, they are already equipped with needle-sharp fangs and extremely toxic venom. It takes between 3 to 4 years for them to reach sexual maturity.

FATAL STRIKE

The western diamondback rattlesnake usually hunts by ambushing its victim, then striking with its long fangs. Its lethal venom contains a mixture of toxins that can kill victims in seconds. The snake waits for its prey to die before eating.



HEAVY-BODIED SNAKE

This bulky snake varies in color according to its location and habitat, and may be gray, brown, olive-green, or reddish brown. The tail is marked with black and white bands just in front of the rattle.

ATTACK AND DEFENSE

The western diamondback rattlesnake is a well-armed and deadly predator that has developed effective methods for hunting prey. However, the solitary snake will often withdraw from confrontation if disturbed, using its rattle to deter intruders.



STALKING PREY

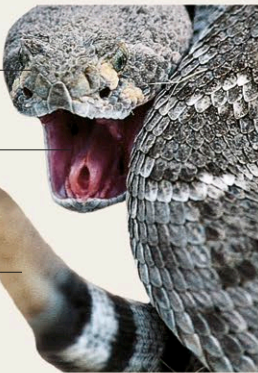
The western diamondback rattlesnake uses the pair of heat-sensitive pits between its eyes and nostrils to detect and locate warm-blooded prey.



heat pits

fanged mouth

buzzing rattle



DEATH RATTLE

The rattlesnake sounds its unmistakable rattle as a means of defense and an ominous warning not to approach.

EATING ITS PREY

Having stunned a rodent victim with its venomous bite, the rattlesnake waits for it to die before swallowing it whole.

